



Small strides: The snack market leader Haldiram's began as a small venture in Bikaner 70 years ago

have propelled much of the country's business to greater heights, it should harness the potential advantages of wise government and expanded education and wider media emphasis on entrepreneurship.

The debate continues between reformists and populists over details of the economic initiatives begun by Rajiv Gandhi in the late 1980s, which paved the way for the economic liberalisation under P.V. Narasimha Rao and the then finance minister Manmohan Singh. But most would agree that India's stunning rate of GDP growth in recent years has lifted millions out of poverty, with the prospect of millions more soon joining them. India needs only to look to the US, a paradise for entrepreneurs, to understand the value of an environment with minimal hurdles to starting a business. In this environment, Indians have flourished.

In addition to advancing the broad investments in infrastructure and human capital that will continue to create a pro-business environment, the government should work with education leaders to bolster India's schools. Since Independence and under the Jawaharlal Nehru government, India has created exceptional engineering schools. Now, in addition to these traditional academic strengths, there is an opportunity to build more academies focused on vocational training to produce electricians, plumbers and other technicians whose expertise will be needed to service India's booming urban infrastructure. This training would greatly increase the potential for new entrepreneurs.

But other emerging opportunities for entrepreneurs exist too, including those in the healthcare sector. For example, as India's life expectancy increases, older people will look for quality assisted living providers. Entrepreneurs who create these institutions will flourish if they take a holistic perspective and understand that their potential customers are not simply the elderly, but the children and grandchildren who will be visiting their older relatives in the nursing home. Creating an environment that meets the needs of the entire family will create value for all involved. Similarly, people who open even small clinics or testing centres where X-rays or blood work can be processed will find reward. Along with healthcare, there will also be entrepreneurial opportunities in "wealthcare",

managing the financial resources of India's citizens. Then, too, the hospitality sector looks to have a vibrant future, as India remains a hotspot for tourism. Entrepreneurs who start small hotels should attract many customers. The scale of these endeavours is less important than is meeting a social need with a quality product or service.

Finally, India's media has an important part to play in spreading prosperity. Newspapers and magazines should get more engaged and feature stories about entrepreneurs and business leaders who are making a difference. Articles that reveal how these people have achieved their success are especially helpful, as are pieces that discuss business strategy, since readers can then gain the inspiration and understanding to start their own ventures. After all, the outcome is the sight, but the process to reach that outcome provides the insight.

Indians have entrepreneurship in their DNA. Unleashing that power requires dream, drive and a diploma. The Indian middle class will continue to grow so long as proper training and education is available to those seeking to better themselves. With commitment from the Indian government to provide the foundations for economic growth, and in partnership with the nation's educational system and media leaders, the road to entrepreneurship has never been so open as it is today.

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Road to Progress

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